

LITERACY FOR COLLEGE SUCCESS



Amee Schmidt & Donald Winter
Literacy for College Success

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Licensing

A detailed breakdown of this resource's licensing can be found in [Back Matter/Detailed Licensing](#).

Introduction and Acknowledgements

This book is a compilation of four primary texts, which we significantly remixed and edited, as well as original compositions of our own. The basis for the organization and the majority of the first two chapters of this book are adapted from Fran Bozarth's *Reading & Writing for Learning*¹. Bozarth's opening chapter provides a clear focus for students entering college—they must create a basis for learning. We supplemented these chapters with material and activities from both Marken² and Martinez, et al.³, which are comprehensive courses dedicated to helping students learn strategies for success in academia. Unit 2 is Bozarth's work on vocabulary skills, with a few edits and a bit of composition from us. We used portions of Babin, et al.⁴ to develop Unit 3, which directs students to analysis and reflection on literary texts, necessary skills for moving forward in college courses. The final chapters go back to material from Bozarth, but also contain significant original contributions of our own. The course finishes with a focus on comprehending authorship and authority, literacy, and persuasion in academic/professional texts.

In addition to the amazing content from our fellow collaborators, special thanks go to Delta College's Librarians and the Instructional Support Team, without whom we wouldn't have been able to complete this book.

What an honor it has been to collaborate with these talented and dedicated educators. We are grateful for the opportunity to create this text for our developmental reading students. As a result of the challenges and surprising fulfillment of creating this book, we have become dedicated to the use of open educational resources (OER) for our students in all classes. We believe that free resources for education is a stepping stone to a worldwide literacy; those who didn't have access before, now do.

Many, many thanks,

Amee Schmidt & Donald Winter

References

1. Fran Bozarth, *Reading & Writing for Learning* <https://www.oercommons.org/courses/reading-writing-for-learning-course-materials>
2. Liv Marken, *Strategies for Academic Success* <http://openpress.usask.ca/strategiesforacademicsuccess/>
3. Graciela Martinez, et. al, *Student Success* <http://www.canyons.edu/Offices/library/Documents/Counseling%20150%20Textbook%20Version%201.pdf>
4. Monique Babin, et al. *The Word on College Reading and Writing* <https://www.oercommons.org/courses/the-word-on-college-reading-and-writing>

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

1: Always Be Prepared

- 1.1: Preparing to Learn
- 1.2: Organizing Your Space
- 1.3: Organizing Your Time
- 1.4: Preparing to Read
- 1.5: Strong vs. Weak Summaries
- 1.6: Preparing to Write
- 1.7: Writing Good Solid Sentences

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1.1: Preparing to Learn

Know Yourself: What is your Learning Style?

“Reading is a complex task. No single part of the brain can do all the work,” (Q. HE)

Believe it or not, we don’t all learn the same way. In fact, reading is a new enough behavior for humans that there is no wiring in our brains specifically for reading. Each and every one of us make those neural connections differently.

This is a good reason to pay attention to your learning preferences. Being aware of your own learning preferences can help you to use strategies and tools for learning that will support what you naturally do. Of course, it’s still important to use strategies that “stretch” your brain a bit too – you never know when you might need those other strategies!

NOTE: Throughout this text, you will complete various **Activities** and **In-Class Exercises**. Here is your first In-Class Exercise.

Exercises

In-Class Exercise 1.1

1. Take the [VARK Questionnaire](http://vark-learn.com/the-vark-questionnaire/) (<http://vark-learn.com/the-vark-questionnaire/>), and record your learning style in your Literacy Journal.
2. Then, look at the strategies for your specific learning style. Make some notes about what you think will be most effective for you as a reader.

There are LOADS of Learning Style Assessments out there, so if you are really interested in this, do a search for **Learning Style Assessments for Adults** and you will find many options. The important thing is to learn more about yourself so you can better support your own learning.

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1.2: Organizing Your Space

The Importance of Organizing Your Space

- Recognize the importance of organizing your space to your best advantage for studying.
- Avoid distractions in the space where you are studying.
- Understand the myth of multitasking and prevent distractions from your personal technology.

People's moods, attitudes, and levels of work productivity change in different spaces. Learning to use space to your own advantage helps get you off to a good start in your studies. Here are a few of the ways space matters:

- **You need your own space.** This may seem simple, but everyone needs some physical area, regardless of size, that is really his or her own—even if it's only a small part of a shared space. Within your own space, you generally feel more secure and in control. If you don't have access to that at home or in your dormitory, ask around (staff and students) to find the quiet and secluded study spaces on campus.
- **Physical space reinforces habits.** For example, using your bed primarily for sleeping makes it easier to fall asleep there than elsewhere and makes it a poor place to try to stay awake and alert for studying.
- **Different places create different moods.** One study space may be bright and full of energy, with happy students passing through—a place that puts you in a good mood. But that may actually make it more difficult to concentrate. Yet the opposite—a totally quiet, austere place devoid of color and sound—can be just as unproductive. Everyone needs to discover what space works best for himself or herself—and then let that space reinforce good study habits.

What's the Best Study Space for You?

Begin by analyzing your needs, preferences, and past problems with places for studying. Where do you usually study? What are the best things about that place for studying? What distractions are most likely to occur there?

The goal is to find, or create, the best place for studying, and then to use it regularly so that studying there becomes a good habit.

- **Choose a place you can associate with studying.** Make sure it's not a place already associated with other activities (eating, watching television, sleeping, etc.). Over time, the more often you study in this space, the stronger will be its association with studying. Make it a pleasant-looking space so you don't dread using it.
- **Your study area should be available whenever you need it.** If you want to use your home, apartment, or dorm room but you never know if another person may be there, then it's probably better to look for another place. Look for locations open at the hours when you may be studying. You may also need two study spaces—maybe you study best at home but have an hour free between two classes.
- **Your study space should meet your study needs.** You'll tire quickly if you try to write notes sitting in an easy chair or a bed (which might also make you sleepy). You need good light for reading to avoid tiring from eyestrain. If you use a laptop for writing notes or reading and researching, you need a power outlet so you don't have to stop when your battery runs out.
- **Your study space should meet your psychological needs.** Some students may need total silence with absolutely no visual distractions; other students may be unable to concentrate without looking up from reading and letting their eyes move over a pleasant scene; some students may stay motivated when surrounded by other students. Experiment to find the setting that works best for you.
- **You may need the support of others to maintain your study space.** Students living at home, whether with a spouse and children or with their parents, often need the support of family members to maintain an effective study space. The kitchen table probably isn't best if others pass by frequently. Be creative, if necessary, and set up a card table in a quiet corner of your bedroom or elsewhere to avoid interruptions. Put a "do not disturb" sign on your door.
- **Keep your space organized and free of distractions.** You want to prevent sudden impulses to neatening up the area (when you should be studying), do laundry, or other chores. Turn off your cell phone, and use your computer only as needed for studying. Turn off your email and message notifications.
- **Plan for breaks.** Everyone needs to take a break occasionally when studying. Think about the space you're in and how to use it when you need a break. Stop and do a few exercises to get your blood flowing, or walk around the area and stretch.
- **Prepare for human interruptions.** Even if you hide in the library to study, there's a chance a friend may happen by. At home with family members or in a dorm room or common space, the odds increase greatly. Have a plan ready in case someone pops in and asks you to join them in some fun activity. Know when you plan to finish your studying so that you can make a plan for later—or for tomorrow at a set time.

The Distractions of Technology

Multitasking is the term commonly used for being engaged in two or more different activities at the same time, usually referring to activities using devices such as cell phones, smartphones, computers, and so on. Many people who have grown up with computers consider this kind of multitasking a normal way to get things done, including studying. However, it's an established fact that multitasking is a myth.

It is true that *some* things can be attended to while you're doing something else, such as checking e-mail while you watch television news—but only when none of those things demands your full attention. You can concentrate 80 percent on the e-mail, for example, while 20 percent of your attention is listening for something on the news that catches your attention. Then you turn to the television for a minute, watch that segment, and go back to the e-mail. But you're not actually watching the television *at the same time* you're composing the e-mail—you're toggling back and forth. In reality, the mind can focus only on one thing at any given moment. Even things that don't require much thinking are severely impacted by multitasking, such as driving while talking on a cell phone or texting.

It actually takes you longer to do two or more things at the same time than if you do them separately—at least with anything that you actually have to focus on, such as studying.

The other problem with multitasking is the effect it can have on the attention span—and even on how the brain works. Research has shown that in people who constantly shift their attention from one thing to another in short bursts, the brain forms patterns that make it more difficult to keep sustained attention on any one thing (Levitin). So when you need to concentrate for a while on one thing, such as when studying for a big test, it becomes more difficult to do even if you're not multitasking at that time. It's as if your mind makes a habit of wandering from one thing to another and then can't stop.

So stay away from multitasking whenever you have something important to do. Manipulate your study space to prevent the temptations. Turn your computer off, or shut down e-mail and messaging programs if you need the computer for studying. Turn your cell phone off—if you just tell yourself not to answer it but still glance at it each time to see who sent or left a message, you're still losing your studying momentum and have to start over again. For those who are really addicted to technology (you know who you are!), go to the library and don't take your laptop or cell phone.

What about listening to music while studying? Some don't consider that multitasking, and many students say they can listen to music without it affecting their studying. But there's a huge difference between listening to your favorite music and spontaneously singing along with some of the songs and enjoying soft background music that enhances your study space the same way as good lighting. Some find that they can only work in total silence, and some are so used to being immersed in music and the sounds of life that they find *total* silence more distracting—such people can often study well in places where people are moving around. The key thing is to be honest with yourself: if you're *actively* listening to music while you're studying, then you're likely not studying as well as you could be. It will take you longer and lead to less successful results (Doraiswamy).

Family and Roommate Issues

Sometimes going to the library or elsewhere is not practical for studying, and you have to find a way to cope in a shared space.

Part of the solution is time management. Agree with others on certain times that will be reserved for studying; agree to keep the place quiet, not to have guests visiting, and to prevent other distractions. These arrangements can be made with a roommate, spouse, and older children. If there are younger children in your household and you have child-care responsibility, it's usually more complicated. You may have to schedule your studying during their nap time or find quiet activities for them to enjoy while you study. The key is to plan ahead.

Finally, accept that sometimes you'll just have to say “no.” If your friend often suggests doing something else when you need to study, be firm but polite as you explain that you just *really* have to get your work done first. Students who live at home may also have to learn how to say no to parents or family members. Remember, you can't be everything to everyone all the time.

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1.3: Organizing Your Time

Learning Objectives

- Discover your time personality and know where your time goes.
- Understand the basic principles of time management and planning.
- Practice time management strategies to help ensure your academic success.

When you know what you want to do, why not just sit down and get it done? The millions of people who complain frequently about “not having enough time” would love it if it were that simple!

Time and Your Personality

People’s attitudes toward time vary widely. One person seems to be always rushing around but actually gets less done than another person who seems unconcerned about time and calmly goes about the day. Since there are so many different “time personalities,” it’s important to realize how you approach time. Start by trying to figure out how you spend your time during a typical week with this exercise.

Exercises

In-Class Exercise 1.3: Where Does the Time Go?

See if you can account for a week’s worth of time by creating this chart in your Literacy Journal. For each of the categories, make your best estimate of how many hours you spend in a week. (You can estimate for one day and multiply by seven for daily activities.)

Category of Activity	# of hours per week
Sleeping	
Eating (including preparing food)	
Personal hygiene (i.e., bathing, etc.)	
Working (employment)	
Volunteer service or internship	
Chores, cleaning, errands, shopping, etc.	
Attending class	
Studying, reading, and researching (outside of class)	
Transportation to work or school	
Getting to classes (walking, biking, etc.)	
Organized group activities (clubs, church services, etc.)	
Time with friends (include television, video games, etc.)	
Attending events (movies, parties, etc.)	
Time alone (include television, video games, surfing the Web, etc.)	
Exercise or sports activities	

Reading for fun or other interests done alone	
Talking on phone, e-mail, Facebook, etc.	

Now total your estimated hours. Is your number larger or smaller than 168, the total number of hours in a week? If your estimate is higher, go back through your list and adjust numbers to be more realistic. But if your total is fewer than 168, don't just add more time in categories. Instead, ponder this: *Where does the time go?* We'll come back to this question.

Plan your tasks according to time of day.

When you need to concentrate, such as when writing a class paper, are you more alert and focused in the morning, afternoon, or evening? Do you concentrate best when you look forward to a relaxing activity later on, or do you study better when you've finished all other activities? Understanding this will help you better plan your study periods.

Estimate your time realistically.

Think about your time analysis in this exercise. People who estimate too high often feel they don't have enough time. They may have time anxiety and often feel frustrated. People at the other extreme, who often can't account for how they use all their time, may have a more relaxed attitude. They may not actually have any more free time, but they may be wasting more time than they want to admit with less important things.

Be prepared for schedule changes.

People also differ in how they respond to schedule changes. Some go with the flow and accept changes easily, while others function well only when following a planned schedule and may become upset if that schedule changes. If you do not react well to an unexpected disruption in your schedule, plan extra time for catching up if something throws you off. This is all part of understanding your time personality.

Time Management

- Time management for successful university studying involves these factors:
- Determining how much time you need to spend studying
- Knowing how much time you actually have for studying and increasing that time if needed
- Being aware of the times of day you are at your best and most focused
- Using effective long- and short-term study strategies
- Scheduling study activities in realistic segments
- Using a system to plan ahead and set priorities
- Staying motivated to follow your plan and avoid procrastination

For every hour in the classroom, university students should spend, on average, about two hours on that class, counting reading, studying, writing papers, and so on. If you're a full-time student with fifteen hours a week in class, then you need another thirty hours for rest of your academic work. That forty-five hours is about the same as a typical full-time job. If you work part time, time management skills are even more essential. These skills are still more important for part-time university students who work full time and commute or have a family. To succeed in university, virtually everyone has to develop effective strategies for dealing with time.

Look back at the number of hours you wrote in *Where Does the Time Go* for a week of studying. Do you have two hours of study time for every hour in class? Many students begin university not knowing this much time is needed, so don't be surprised if you underestimated this number of hours. Remember this is just an average amount of study time—you may need more or less for your own courses.

Set and Commit to Your Schedule

Put your schedule on a calendar and post it where you and other people in your life can easily refer to it.

Once you've allotted time for study, stick to it. If you occasionally have more time than you need for your assignments, try working ahead. Get a jump on a paper or on the next chapter of the textbook – you'll thank yourself later. Sure, you may need to adjust for

the surprises, both good and bad, that pop up in all of our lives, but if you've made a place in your schedule for your school work, you won't have to face the stress of rearranging your activities at the last minute.

Making your schedule consistent and available to the important people in your life (including you) will help you to develop study habits that will make your investment in college a successful one.

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1.4: Preparing to Read

Why Am I reading this?

You may be thinking to yourself, “Prepare to read? Don’t I just pick the text up and read it?” The answer to this is yes and no. It depends on your purpose for reading.

Homework 1: All the Things I Read

You read all the time, and you have your own reasons for doing so. Brainstorm a list of all the different things you read throughout the day. Think about walking through the halls, driving down the road, sitting in a waiting room, etc. All of these different things we read change the way in which we read and affect the way we comprehend the world.

1. In a complete paragraph (3-4 full sentences), write how the different things you read influence the *way you approach reading*, the *purpose* you have for reading, and the *way you understand* what you read.

How to Read Academic Texts

As you may have noticed, different purposes for reading affect the way you choose to read a given text. Academic texts are typically selected as a source of information or to provide a different perspective. You will be expected to learn from, explain, or use this kind of textual material to support your stance on a topic.

The kind of **passive reading** you may do when you read a light novel will not be helpful for you with academic texts. For this kind of learning you will need to use **active reading** strategies.

Active Reading Strategies

Have you ever read something and then realized you don’t remember a word of what you just read? That is because you were passively reading – you were not engaged in the text. The following suggestions will help you to stay engaged in what you read so that you can learn it or use it later.

Successful students approach reading with a strategy that helps them get the most out of their reading. These students read actively. They look for the main idea of the material, its themes, and for words they do not understand.

The opposite of reading actively is reading passively. Passive readers simply skip over things they do not understand and have difficulty understanding the material as a result.

In this course, we are going to practice active reading. You will find that active reading is more enjoyable, lets you understand more of what you have read, and leads to better test scores.

SQ3R

Active reading strategies can significantly increase learning new information. SQ3R is one of the most popular active reading strategies designed to help retain information into long term memory. SQ3R is a five-step process.



The five steps involved in the SQ3R include:

Step 1. Survey – What can I learn from the text?

Pre-reading Strategy – When you read an academic text, it is well worth your time to skim/scan the reading first. Think out loud the first few times you do this. Look for the title, headings/subheadings, bold words, graphics, and other features of the text that stand out to you, and make notes about these on the reading or in your notebook:

- Skim the table of contents and write down three to five main ideas that will be presented in the text.
- Write down important names, headings, and subheadings.
- Look at the captions under images, tables, diagrams and maps; make notes of where this information exists.
- Pay particular attention to the introductory and final paragraphs, which often contain a summary of the text. Write down a few key ideas from both paragraphs.

Step 2. Question – What do I hope to learn from the text?

Before reading a section, formulate your own questions and do the following:

- Rephrase headings and titles into questions you hope to answer.
- Look whether the author has formulated questions at the beginning or end of the section. Rewrite these questions in your own words.
- Predict what you think the section will be about. Turn this prediction into a question you think the section will answer.
- Recall what you already know about the topic and what you still want to learn about it.
- Write out all the questions for consideration. You'll find answers to the questions in the next step.

Step 3. Read & Annotate! – Look for answers to your questions.

- Always read with a pen and highlighter in hand (or keyboard). See the handout on “Annotating a Text” before reading your assigned text.
- Read captions under images and diagrams. Pay attention to highlighted information.
- Be open-minded – pay attention to new ideas and differing opinions.
- Reduce your speed and/or stop and reread difficult and unclear parts.
- Look for answers to the questions you first raised during the questioning that took place in step 2. Write out the answers to these questions.
- Answer questions at the beginning or end of the chapters.
- Note all the underlined, italicized, bold printed words or phrases.
- Read only a section at a time and *recite* after each section.

Step 4. Recite – Consider what you want to remember from the information obtained.

- Think about what you've read and summarize the main ideas expressed in the section.
- If you realize there is something you have not fully understood, reread that section.
- Take notes, expressing ideas in your own words. Try your hand at the Cornell Notes strategy.
- Reciting: The more senses you use the more likely you are to remember what you read. To triple strength learning apply: seeing, saying and hearing. To quadruple strength learning apply: seeing, saying, hearing, and writing!

Step 5. Recall – Reread your notes and link the information with your own experience.

- After reading the whole text, reread your own notes and pay attention to the main ideas and connections between the ideas.
- Link what you have learned with your own experience and other sources of information.
- This step is an ongoing process.

Exercises

In-Class Exercise 1.4: SQ3R

1. Pre-read the book assigned by your instructor using Step 1 of SQ3R. Make notes about each bullet in Step 1 of SQ3R, and mark up the text with your pre-reading notation. Answer the following question in a complete paragraph.
2. What have you learned from this article simply by pre-reading? Be sure to clearly identify and define the following: Topic, Author's Point, and Key Terms.
3. We will review your pre-reading notes in class. Then, in pairs or small groups, we will complete the SQ3R sequence. Be sure to bring your annotated article to class!

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1.5: Strong vs. Weak Summaries

A summary should be a condensed (shorter) version of a larger reading. You often see examples of everyday use of summaries when you want to know more about a television show or movie, or when you look over the back cover of a book to see if you want to read it. However, you will also see them used in academic circles – for example when you want to know if you might find a particular journal article useful for a research paper, you will take a look at the *abstract*.

Writing a summary can be a very useful learning tool. At first, a summary will take you awhile to write, but with practice you can get pretty efficient with them. Summarizing has been found to help students clarify what is important in a reading, become familiar with a variety of structures used to effectively communicate in writing, review essential terminology, and generally make sense of the text. (MARZANO)

Exercises

In-Class Exercise 1.5: Summaries

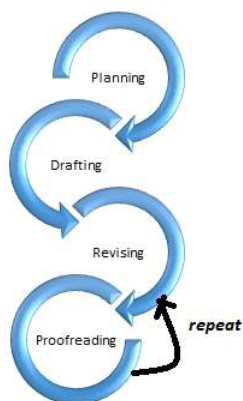
Read the summaries written by previous students. One is labeled “Strong Summary” and two are labeled “Weak Summary.” Answer the following questions in complete sentences and paragraphs (when appropriate).

1. Make two lists: One listing the qualities or traits of Strong Summaries, and the other listing the qualities or traits of Weak Summaries.
2. What is the purpose of writing summaries? How can they be useful to us as learners?
3. Keeping in mind the purpose of a summary, identify and define the traits a summary should have. Explain how these traits make it strong and useful to a learner?

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1.6: Preparing to Write

Many students are under the impression that once they are given a prompt for a writing assignment, they should just sit down and write. This is not the case at all! In fact, many professional writers use a system called the Writing Process. It goes something like this:



Step 1: Plan what you want to write. This may just be some general notes or be as structured as an outline. A thesis is usually developed in this step.

Step 2: Write a **first draft** of your piece. In this day and age this should take place on a computer – you’ll be glad you did later when you make revisions and you don’t have to completely rewrite your piece.

Step 3. Revising involves making changes you notice would make your piece better.

Step 4: Proofreading is not something you do alone. Typically you will proofread your own work, but then you will want to get some fresh eyes on it. We will work on strategies for proofreading in this class.

Steps 3 and 4 may be repeated endlessly. If you are a perfectionist, you will want to decide at some point that your work is “good enough” and turn in a final draft.

Why Am I writing this?

Just as your purpose for reading affects how you read, your purpose for writing affects how you write. A quick note doesn’t typically require extensive use of the writing process, but for some other reasons you might write, use of the writing process is vital!

In your Literacy Journal, list some reasons you may want to write well.

Writer's Purpose

Understanding an author’s purpose for writing is vital to not only structuring your own work, but is also essential to comprehending any text that you might read. After all, every text is written by someone; keep in mind that all writers have reasons for writing what they write. Not all reasons are formal – sometimes a writer writes in order to respond or react informally to a text.

Writers typically write formally for one (or a combination) of three purposes:

- To Inform
- To Entertain
- To Persuade

Look Ahead

Check your syllabus. What assignments are coming up to which you will apply the writing process? When will these be due?

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1.7: Writing Good Solid Sentences

Visit the [Purdue OWL](http://owl.purdue.edu) (owl.purdue.edu) and find materials to learn about and summarize what makes a good solid sentence.

Exercises

In-class Exercise 1.7: Sentences

In your Literacy Journal, write notes for each heading. Then consolidate these into a summary.

Qualities of a Complete Sentence

- 1.
- 2.
- 3.

When to Use Commas

- 1.
- 2.
- 3.

Define a sentence fragment

Compare and contrast Run-ons & Comma Splices

Unit 1 Review

In complete sentences and paragraphs, answer the following questions to review what you've learned in Unit 1 of this textbook.

1. Identify the Topic of Unit 1.
2. Identify and define Key Words/Terms from Unit 1.
3. Identify and explain the Main Ideas from Unit 1.
4. Visit the Course Resources section at the back of this book and learn how to write Sentence Summaries. Then, write a sentence summary for Unit 1. (Note: the information you've provided in questions 1-3 will help you to compose a condensed Sentence Summary of Unit 1).

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

2: Comprehending and Communicating Clearly

2.1: Words Influence Literacy

2.2: What is the Point? Thesis and Main Ideas

2.3: Using a Main Idea to Organize Your Paragraph

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2.1: Words Influence Literacy

Vocabulary Strategies: Preparing to Comprehend What You Read

Why do instructors insist on teaching you vocabulary? It turns out your ability to understand key vocabulary in a reading directly affects your ability to comprehend the overall text. (QUIAN)

This section will focus upon strategies for **comprehending** the meanings of **key words** in a text without using the dictionary unless absolutely necessary. Conversely, there will also be a focus upon the way in which you, as a writer, use words to **effectively communicate** your ideas.

The Big Picture: Context Clues

Context refers to surrounding time, place, and circumstances of a situation. We make assumptions about what happens in the world around us by observing context. Consider the following narrative in which a student observes other students in the library:

"I was at the library at 12:30 PM and I saw a group of five girls studying. They all were wearing sweatpants, two of girls had coffees and one was eating a sandwich. It looked like they had been there for a long time because there were wrappers and crumpled paper on the table. I wasn't sure what they were studying, but I thought it was math because they had calculators and were doing some problems, but they were engaged. After about 30 minutes of me being there, they took a break and when one of them left, they were talking and laughing and were on their phones, two of the girls left for approximately 5 minutes and came back; I assumed they went to the bathroom. They came back and continued to study for another 30 minutes and they all packed up their books and notebooks and left."

Homework 2: Observing Context

Situate yourself somewhere on campus, or somewhere there are people doing activities. Observe this setting, paying special attention to the details of the situation. Answer the following questions in complete sentences and paragraphs, in no less than 250 words.

1. Write a brief description of what you observe. Note only the raw details of the situation: time, place, and circumstances.
2. Based on what you observe happening, explain what you think might be going on in this situation. How do you know what these people are doing?

Context Clues are specific to reading – they are clues found in the surrounding text that help the reader to define a **keyword**.

Why use context clues? This is a very effective and efficient way to get the general meaning of a word that does not interrupt the flow of your reading. You can find the meaning of a word by reading the sentence and considering the words around it

Kinds of Context clues

Exercises

In-Class Exercise 2.1: Context Clues

Part 1: Watch the video, [Word Attack! Using Context Clues to Become a Word Ninja](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pbqJ...ature=youtu.be) (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pbqJ...ature=youtu.be>) . Take careful notes while watching so you can answer the following questions. In complete sentences, define the following kinds of context clues.

1. Definition Clues
2. Synonym/Example Clues
3. Antonym/Contrast Clues
4. GIST

Part 2: Use the SQ3R reading process to read and annotate the assigned reading provided by your instructor. Make a list of 8-10 **key terms** that you can define using context clues. Assume that you would need to learn this text well enough to take a quiz on it.

1. **In complete sentences, in your own words**, define the key terms you listed in your notes. Be sure to tell which kind of context clue(s) you used to derive your working definition. Be sure to *reference the specific text of the sentence* and *explain* how you

derived the definition.

Bits & Pieces: Word Parts

Your “Plan B” for determining the meaning of a key word should be using **word parts**, or morphemes. Word parts are exactly what it sounds like – the reader breaks the word into parts and derives meaning by using what is known about the part’s meaning. It doesn’t necessarily interrupt the flow of reading, but, depending upon the reader, it may briefly.

There are Three Categories of Morphemes

Root Words

- Roots are the basis of complex words.
- Prefixes or suffixes may be added to them to modify the meaning.

Prefixes

- Prefixes are **added to the beginning** of a word to modify the meaning.

Suffixes

- Suffixes are **added to the end** of a word to modify the meaning.

Let’s try this out. Here is how word parts can be used to define the word “irreversible.”

Break the word into syllables: ir-re-vers-i-ble

At this point, determining which syllables make up which parts can be kind of like solving a mystery. The more word parts you are familiar with, the easier this becomes.

- **Root:** verse (meaning: *turning*)
- **Prefix:** re (meaning: *again*)
 - “reverse” means to turn again, to go back
- **Suffix:** ible (meaning: *able to*)
 - “reversible” means able to turn again, or able to turn back
- **Prefix:** ir (meaning: *not*)
 - “irreversible” means not able to turn again, or not able to turn back

Why Would I Do This?

Knowing word parts is efficient. It turns out that when a reader knows a set of 20 prefixes and 14 roots, and knows how to use them, they will unlock the meaning of over 100,000 words. (Imagine adding suffixes!) Would you rather learn 20 prefixes and 14 roots, or would you rather learn the individual definitions of over 100,000 words?

If you are entering a vocational program where there is a large amount of vocabulary, such as medical fields, this is THE way to learn key vocabulary, because discipline-specific vocabulary is often based upon specific, regularly occurring word parts.

Morphemes develop over time, so knowing the etymology, or history, of a morpheme adds to your understanding of them and their many variations.

Tips for Working With Morphemes

- In *most* cases, a word is built on at least one root.
- Words *can* have more than one prefix, root, or suffix.
- Words *do not always* have both a prefix and a suffix
- Roots *may* change in spelling as they are combined with suffixes (arid arable)
- *Sometimes* you may identify a group of letters as a prefix or root, but find that it does not carry the meaning of the prefix or root.

When to use the Dictionary

Stopping to look up unknown words *while* you are reading is highly disruptive to the flow of reading. It effectively keeps you from understanding the broader message of a text. For that reason, we try to determine meanings of key words AS we read, perhaps

marking words to look up later. Then return to the reading later to try out your understanding. Using the dictionary to understand key terms should be your LAST option.

That being said, there are many good reasons to use a dictionary. Use a dictionary to:

- Look up key words **before or after** reading a text.
- Learn how to pronounce a word correctly.
- Find out the origins or history of a word.
- Determine how to correctly break the word into syllables.

Dictionaries have changed considerably over the years, making them much easier to use. You can certainly use a printed book dictionary, or an online dictionary, which are often free, and typically provide audio so you can learn to how to pronounce an unknown word.

Look Ahead

Check your syllabus. What assignments are coming up that you will apply your understanding of vocabulary strategies to? When will this be due?

Keep It Interesting: Word Choice & Descriptive Writing

Read these two passages:

- The sun set, turning the sky red.
- The sunset filled the sky with the deep color of rubies, setting the clouds ablaze.

Both sentences describe a sunset, but they do so differently. Compare the two sentences.

Descriptive writers use several tools to show rather than tell. In other words, good descriptive writing can help the reader to have a clearer understanding of what the author is trying to communicate. In this class we will work with three descriptive writing tools – **vivid language, sensory details, and figurative language.**

Vivid Language

Vivid language, unlike plain language, is used by writers to provide a very specific description. Writers choose specific words or combinations of words to clearly communicate to the reader. The sunset sentence above is an excellent example of this.

Sensory Details

What is the root word of “sensory?”

Sensory details are considered to be a category of vivid language. Writers use sensory details – that is, what the way something looks, smells, sounds, tastes, or feels on our skin.

Figurative Language Basics

You may have heard the term “figure of speech.” We humans tend to learn about new things by comparing them to things we already understand, and that is what happens when we use figurative language.

One way to remember “figurative language” is to remember that it is the opposite of “literal language.” Literal refers to actual, factual description of something. **Figurative language** compares a word to something it is not obviously like.

For example, you could describe slow traffic:

Literal: Cars are moving very slowly on the roads today.

Figurative: Traffic is moving slower than a herd of turtles today.

Understanding figurative language will help you to *discover meaning* and find *main ideas*.

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2.2: What is the Point? Thesis and Main Ideas

Main ideas provide the structure for our efforts at communication. You may also know main ideas under their alias, “topic sentence.”

- In **reading** we analyze main ideas to better understand what an author or speaker is trying to communicate.
- In **writing** we use main ideas to organize paragraphs so that our audience can better understand what we are trying to communicate.

Stated Main Idea

Stated main ideas are exactly what they sound like – main ideas that are directly stated in a passage. You can literally underline or highlight a stated main idea in a text, and you should do this when you are reading a textbook for a class.

Implied Main Idea: What are you trying to say?

The word **implied** means “suggested but not directly expressed.” Use this definition to help you define “implied main idea.”

What is an “implied main idea?”

How is an implied main idea different from a stated main idea?

How to find the Elusive Main idea

How can you identify the main idea in a text or spoken communication? Whether you are looking at a stated main idea or an implied main idea, the following strategies can help.

Strategy 1:

Ask yourself:

- What is the point of the piece?
- What is the one thing the author/speaker wants me to know about this?

Strategy 2:

- If you are still struggling to locate the main idea, back up and identify the topic. The **topic** is a word or phrase that the paragraph is about.
- Then ask yourself “what about” the topic? This is likely the main idea.
- It never hurts to discuss the piece with another person. Sometimes this helps you to clarify your understanding.

Strategy 3 – for implied main ideas:

- Read the passage for which you are seeking a main idea. Look for words or ideas that are repeated frequently.
- Then use Strategy 2 to derive your own version of a main idea statement.

Main Ideas and Details are in a Relationship

Main ideas and supporting details have a pretty simple relationship. The main idea is the center of attention, and the supporting details function to support the main idea. If these were two people, this would be a pretty unfair relationship, but in writing or speaking, it is entirely acceptable. After all, only one idea can be the ‘focus.’

Whether you are reading, treasure-hunting to find main ideas and supporting details in your textbook, or you are writing an essay, a graphic organizer can be a helpful tool. There are all kinds of graphic organizers and metaphors for working with main ideas and supporting details, but sometimes it’s more efficient to use a simple diagram. Review the diagrams and graphic organizers for main ideas by doing a Google search.

Look Ahead

Check your syllabus. What assignments are coming up to which you will apply your understanding of main ideas and supporting details? When will this be due?

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2.3: Using a Main Idea to Organize Your Paragraph

Once you have selected a point (main idea) you want to make in a paragraph, you can then decide what else you want to say (support) about that point. The support you choose will depend upon your purpose for writing.

Example 1: If you are writing a *descriptive paragraph* (describes) or *narrative paragraph* (tells a story) you will use vivid language to support your description.

Topic: pie

Main Idea: I love pie.

Support:

- Tastes like
- Looks like
- Smells like
- Sounds when there is pie
- Texture/feel of pie

What is the author's purpose in this kind of writing?

Example 2: If you are writing an *expository paragraph*, your details would include the step or parts that make up whatever it is you are trying to explain.

Topic: pie

Main Idea: Make your pie crust a work of art.

Support:

- Items needed
- Process for making a pie crust decorative
- Baking the pie crust

What is the author's purpose in this kind of writing?

Example 3: If you are writing a *persuasive paragraph*, your details will necessarily include your reasons for your opinion.

Topic: pie

Main Idea: Homemade Pie is better than cake.

Support:

- Pies are made from scratch with relatively few ingredients that can be used for many other purposes, cakes might be made with a mix full of chemical ingredients, or require a number of special ingredients that are often only used for making cake (like cake flour)
- Pies are versatile – they can be filled with everything from sweet fruit or cream fillings to savory fillings such as meat, vegetables, cheese and/or eggs.
- Pies can be made in around 15 minutes if you know what you are doing, and cakes take hours.
- Pies bake up pretty reliably, cakes are very fragile and can become ruined at any step of the baking/assembling process.

Structuring a Paragraph

Speaking of pie, the following P.I.E. Paragraph Structure format is a tool you can use for not only analyzing a paragraph when you read it, but is also useful for planning paragraphs that you want to write.

P.I.E. Paragraph Structure

P = Point	What is the point of the paragraph? What claim is being made? Often, but not always, the point is the TOPIC SENTENCE (Exception: implied main ideas.)

I = Information	How is the point supported with specific data, experiences, factual material or sensory details? The information supports or develops the paragraph's main point.
E = Ending	This sentence either brings the paragraph to a close and/or provides a transition to the next paragraph.

Exercises

In-Class Exercise 2.3: P.I.E.

Scan the following descriptive paragraph. Then read, analyzing for P.I.E. Mark the paragraph, identifying each component of the paragraph.

Example of a descriptive paragraph:

When I was a child, my Dad would sometimes take me with him to visit his mother, my Grandma Nellie. Grandma made the best pie in the world, and when we arrived, we would often find some elderly men sitting at Grandma Nellie's table enjoying pie and coffee. Dad and I would join in, and I'd listen to the funny stories while enjoying a hot cup of coffee with cream, and a slice of Grandma Nellie's homemade pie. I think this was the beginning of my love affair with pie. I love pie. I have to agree with Dad when he says his favorite kind of pie is "hot pie, cold pie and warm pie." I love mixing the flour, butter, pinch of salt, and water to make a nice pliable but flakey pastry. I love when the crust rolls out in an almost perfect, thin circle. I love creating little designs on the top crust. Apple or peach, cherry or marionberry, apricot or blueberry-rhubarb, no filling is wrong. When the raw pie goes into the oven, I even love cleaning up the floury mess that is on the counter. The timer goes off, the pie is golden brown, the bubbly fruit filling sends a scent sneaking through the house into every room. People drift into the kitchen and ask, "Is it ready yet?" The hour or two waiting for the pie to cool enough to serve seems like a lifetime, but eventually the pie does cool. I brew up a pot of coffee, and everyone sips on it, anticipating the flaky warm pie to come. Before we know it, we are all sitting at the table sharing hot coffee, funny stories, and warm pieces of pie topped with a scoop of cold vanilla ice cream. No matter what is going on in the world, for that window of time, we are happy.

P = Point	
I = Information	
E = Ending	

Look Ahead

Check your syllabus. What assignments are coming up to which you will apply your understanding of paragraph structure? When will this be due?

Unit 2 Review

Write an **Important Thing Summary** for Unit 2 to review the information you learned. Follow the steps below to complete the activity:

1. Review your notes from Unit 2, and identify the topic, key terms, and main ideas in this Unit.
2. Visit the Course Resources section of this book and learn how to write the "Important Thing Summary."
3. Write an Important Thing Summary of Unit 2 of this textbook using the information you learned in the previous step.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

3: Discover, Explore, and Reflect on a Text

- 3.1: Discover What a Text is Trying to Say
- 3.2: Explore the Ways the Text Affects You
- 3.3: Reflect on the Writing
- 3.4: Details, Providing Context, and Organization
- 3.5: Analysis of Literature - a Primer of Literary Devices

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3.1: Discover What a Text is Trying to Say

All texts—whether fiction or nonfiction—carry layers of information, built one on top of the other. As we read, we peel those back—like layers in an onion—and uncover deeper meanings.

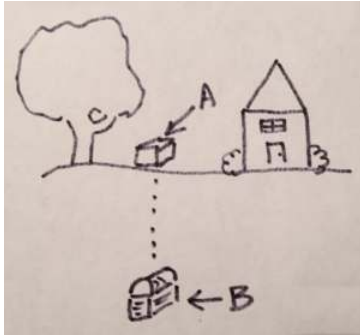


Figure 1, Hidden Meaning

Take a look at Figure 1. We can explain the “deeper meaning” concept by investigating this figure. All texts and stories have surface meaning. In the sketch, this is represented by all the things we see above ground: the tree, the house, and the box (A), along with whatever is in it—even though the box may be closed, anyone who walks by can see it and explore it. These items are concrete and obvious. In “Goldilocks and the Three Bears,” for example, the surface story is about a little girl who goes for a walk in the forest, wanders into the bears’ home, gets into their belongings, and is frightened off.

But stories and essays also have deeper, hidden meanings. In Figure 1, there’s a buried treasure chest (B) deep underground, waiting to be discovered and opened. Texts are much the same—they each contain obvious, surface level meanings, and they each contain a buried prize as well. What’s the deeper meaning in “Goldilocks”? Most fables and fairy tales were designed to teach, warn, or scare. Perhaps the author wants us to think about what happens when we invade people’s privacy. Or maybe it’s about the drawbacks of curiosity. What do you think?

When working with a text, be aware of everything that is happening within it—almost as if you’re watching a juggler with several balls in the air at one time:

- Consider the characters or people featured in the text, their dialog, and how they interact.
- Be aware of the plot’s movement (in a fictional story) or the topic development (in a nonfiction story or essay) and the moments of excitement or conflict as the action rises and falls.
- Look for changes in time—flashbacks, flash-forwards, and dream sequences.
- Watch for themes (ideas that occur, reappear, and carry meaning or a message throughout the piece) or symbols (objects or ideas that stand for or mean something else; these carry meaning that we often understand quickly without thinking about it too much).

Examples of themes: coming of age, redemption, the nature of honesty, conflict, sacrifice.

Examples of symbols: full moon (typically suggests mystery), dark forest (danger or the possibility of being lost), white flag (surrender), a path or road (journey).

As you read, always look for both surface meanings and those buried beneath the surface, like treasure. That’s the fun part of reading—finding those precious hidden bits, waiting to be uncovered and eager to make your reading experience richer and deeper. Even if you just scratch the surface, you’ll learn more.

More About Figurative Language

Much of our work so far has been around academic texts, which emphasize **literal language**. You got an introduction to figurative language in Unit 2, but we will need to look more deeply into it. Much literature and other descriptive texts use **figurative language**. Here are some elements you will want to pay attention to when you are reading your assigned novel for this course and other texts:

Exercises

In-Class Exercise 3.1: Figurative Language Table

After the figurative language lecture, complete the table with examples from the novel you are reading for this class.

Term	Definition	Example
Literal Language or Denotation	The dictionary definition of a word(s).	
Connotation	The social overtones, cultural or emotional meanings of a word(s)	
Figurative Language	Describing something by making a comparison to something else.	
Simile	A comparison using words such as “like” or “as”	
Metaphor	A direct comparison NOT using “like” or “as”	
Oxymoron	A word combining two words that have opposite meanings	
Personification	Giving human traits to non-human creatures, things or ideas.	
Hyperbole	Exaggerating to show strong effect.	
Understatement	An expression with less emphasis than expected (Opposite of a Hyperbole)	

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3.2: Explore the Ways the Text Affects You

When you work with a text, you enter into a conversation with it, responding with your thoughts, ideas, and feelings. The way each of us responds to any text has a lot to do with who we are: our age, education, cultural background, religion, ethnicity, and so forth. As you explore a text, be aware of how you're responding to it.

Exercises

In-Class Exercise 3.2: Exploring a Text

Use these questions to Annotate the reading. Make notes in your Literacy Journal.

- Are you reading or exploring easily and fluidly, or are you finding it difficult to navigate the text? Why do you believe this is so?
- Do you find yourself responding with some sort of strong emotion? If so, why do you think that may be happening?
- Do formatting or structural issues (examples: unusual use of punctuation, use of dialect or jargon) affect your navigation of the text?
- Can you identify with the text's central idea or the information it's sharing?
- Have you had any experiences like those being described? Can you identify with the story?
- Are you able to identify the surface meaning?
- Have you explored the text's deeper, hidden messages?
- Do you need to look up any words to do any quick research? If so, does this help you better understand the text?
- What questions do you have about the work?

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3.3: Reflect on the Writing

As first introduced in Unit 1 with SQ3R and Summary writing, it's worth your time to stop and reflect on all the reading you do in college. This not only helps you think about the content and what it means to you, but it also helps cement it within your memory, allowing you to recall the key ideas later and to apply them in other reading and writing situations.

Homework 3: Summary and Reflection

First, read the *short story* provided for Activity 6.

Next, write a 1-page summary-reflection paper which must include:

- One short paragraph *summarizing* the content of the story. Remember that a summary should focus on the main points of the text. (Refer back to your notes from Unit 1 for a refresher on writing summaries).
- Two paragraphs *reflecting* on your experience of the story. Include details about what you learned, what surprised you, what it made you think about, and/or how it affected you personally, professionally, psychologically and/or emotionally.
- Refer back to the questions in 3.2 Explore the Way the Text Affects You for more ideas of how to compose a reflection.

We will discuss these reflections in class.

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3.4: Details, Providing Context, and Organization

We read to understand, and we write or speak to be understood; details are vital to building that understanding. You have all heard snippets of conversation that seem very odd when heard without the rest of the conversation. News and social media are notorious for taking quotations *out of context* – something we call a “sound bite.”

Why is it a problem to take a sentence out of context?

Exercises

In-Class Exercise 3.4: Context and Details

Read the assigned reading and take notes on the following. After taking notes, be ready to discuss:

1. What is the author’s point in this reading?
2. How did the author support the point?
3. What details did the author provide to give you this idea?

Connect the dots: Organizing with Transitions

When you are analyzing a reading, or planning an essay, supporting details **are** simply listed without context. When analyzing a reading, the reader needs to use the Reading Process in order develop the context before taking notes so that there is clarity about what is important in the text. A writer, of course, has a context in mind when planning an essay, and adds this in with supporting details and transitions.

It may seem like organizing supporting details is pretty ‘cut and dried.’ To some degree this is true, however, an author’s intent has a great deal to do with **how** details get organized. The system of organization an author selects also affects the kinds of transition words and phrases an author uses. Some different kinds of organizational patterns include: Cause and Effect, Chronological, Process, Comparison and Contrast, among many others. Transition words will signal these kinds of organizational patterns.

Compare-Contrast Patterns

A compare and contrast pattern arranges information according to how two or more things are similar to or different from one another (or both). This is an effective pattern to use when the reader can better understand one subject when it is described in relation to another. If the reader is familiar with one topic, the writer can compare or contrast it with another topic to shed insight on it.

For example, suppose a writer’s stated purpose is to help the reader make an informed decision about whether to attend a two-year college or a four-year university. One way to arrange the information is to compare and contrast the two educational options along several important criteria, such as 1) cost, 2) quality of education, and 3) variety of educational programs. In this case, the number of main sections in the outline would depend on how many criteria or factors were considered (three in the case above). Another way to arrange the information would be to create two main sections, one that describes similarities and one that describes differences; within the sections, the writer would evaluate each of the criteria as noted above. Notice that either format could be equally effective.

Chronological Patterns

A chronological pattern of organization arranges information according to a progression of time, either forward or backward. When a topic is best understood in terms of different segments of time, a chronological format works well. For example, topics of an historical nature are best organized using this pattern.

Topical Pattern

This pattern is the most commonly used format, and will typically work when the other patterns do not. A topical pattern arranges information according to different sub-topics within a larger topic, or the “types” of things that fall within a larger category. Using this pattern, each “type” represents a main section of information.

For example, suppose a writer wished to describe various types of wine. One way to outline this information would be to divide the type of wine by its color. A second way would be to divide the types of wine by the region in which they were made.

Combination Patterns

More often than not, you will find yourself using a combination of organizational patterns, particularly in analysis. For instance, while using a topical organization for your essay on wine, you could also use a compare-contrast pattern within each topic to evaluate the wines you're using.

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3.5: Analysis of Literature - a Primer of Literary Devices

All stories share certain characteristics called literary devices. You will want to pay special attention to these as you read and analyze the novel for this class.

Setting

Setting is the time, place and circumstances in which the story is set. This is generally communicated at the beginning of a work of literature, but not always.

Characters

Characters are the people or beings in the story. Common language for describing characters are:

Protagonist – the main character

Antagonist – the character who “antagonizes” or is opposite the protagonist. In some stories this is referred to as “The bad guy.”

Supporting Characters – these characters are not as deeply developed as the protagonist, but are needed in order to tell the story.

Point of View

Point of View (POV) is the perspective from which the story is being told. Common language for POV are:

- **First Person** – the story is being told by the main character using first person pronouns like “I” or “me.” This is commonly used in storytelling.
 - “It was times like these when I thought my father, who hated guns and had never been to any wars, was the bravest man who ever lived.” – *To Kill a Mockingbird* by Harper Lee
- **Second Person** – the story is being told to you personally. The teller uses the pronouns “you” and “your.” This is not as commonly used in storytelling.
 - Consider what *you* could do with a chip in *your* head that linked directly to the Internet: Within milliseconds, *you* could retrieve just about any piece of information. And with the collective knowledge of the Web at *your* disposal, *you* could quickly fill in *your* brain’s normal memory gaps—no one would ever guess *you* slept through that economics seminar.” (Maria Konnikova, “Brain Hacking.” *The Atlantic*, June 2015)
- **Third Person** – a narrator or someone outside of the story is telling the story. Often uses the characters’ names and pronouns “it,” “he,” or “she.” This is commonly used in storytelling.
 - “It was a bright cold day in April, and the clocks were striking thirteen.” – George Orwell, *1984*

Plot

Plot refers to the sequence of events that make up the storyline.

- **Conflict** is a specific plot element regarding the struggle or challenge the protagonist faces, and is the central issue around which the story revolves. There are several kinds of conflict.
- There are many ways this can play out in a story, however “The Big Five” are:
 - Man vs. Man, Man vs. Nature, Man vs. Society, Man vs. Self, Man vs. Technology. (Note – in this case, the term “man” refers to the protagonist whether human or not.)
- **Resolution** describes how the conflict is resolved. You might think of this as how the story ends.

Theme

Identifying the theme in a work of literature can be challenging, especially if this is the first time you do it. One thing that may challenge you is that there is no “right” answer when it comes to identifying theme.

For our purposes, **theme** is the central idea or point the author is trying to make.

How can you, the reader, pick out the theme in a work of literature?

- **Read** the text.
- **Respond** as you read. Annotate!! – make notes in the margin (unless it is a library book.) Keeping a reading journal can really help here.

- Using the title of the work and your observations of the setting, characters, plot and description, **determine the topic** being addressed. (Remember, topic is a word or phrase, and is very general.)
- Once the topic is identified ask yourself, “What is the author’s point about this topic?” The answer you determine is the **theme**, and should be stated as a complete sentence. (*Note the similarity to finding the main idea.*)
- The theme you select may be different than the theme another reader selects. Theme is subjective – it resides in the mind of the reader, and every reader is different. **The key to successfully selecting a theme is backing up your point with evidence from the text.**

Unit 3 Review

1. Compose a one-paragraph summary of the content for Unit 3, focusing on the most important information for you as a reader and writer.
2. Pick out one idea from this unit which you are still unclear about. Explain what doesn’t make sense or what is causing you trouble.
3. Finally, write a one-paragraph reflection of your experience reading your novel. What has been most interesting to you? How are you relating to the text? What kind of impact might this reading have on you?

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

4: Subtleties of Reading and Writing - Author's Style

- 4.1: The Important Thing About Author's Style
- 4.2: Inferences: Text + Experience
- 4.3: Creating Tone and Mood with Thoughtful Diction
- 4.4: Facts, Opinion, Basic Fallacies
- 4.5: Fact & Opinion in Reading

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4.1: The Important Thing About Author's Style

We have been working with text on a basic level – simply figuring out how the author has communicated directly (how they organized their work, and what it is they are trying to convey.) This is an important set of reading skills, and you will use this in many areas of your life, including academia. There is another quite important role here for using basic comprehension strategies; these form a vital skill set as the basis for higher level thinking skills such as analysis, evaluation, and creativity.

The important thing about author's style is that we need to pay attention to the author's use of subtleties in order to better comprehend. English language is filled with nuances. Authors get their meaning across by using a number of tools:

- ***inference***,
- ***word choice***,
- use of ***facts***,
- and use of ***opinions***.

This section focuses upon how to identify and use these elements for reading and comprehension.

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4.2: Inferences: Text + Experience

The basis of “inference” is “infer.” Use word parts to determine a general meaning of this word.

Exercises

In-Class Exercise 4.2: Inferences

1. Watch the video “[Introduction to Reading Skills: Making Inferences](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=acZzllpIYz4)” (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=acZzllpIYz4>). In your Literacy Journal, take notes from the video, and answer the following:
 - Define Inference
 - Describe an inference you made today.
2. Practice Inferring. Read the story below about Paul and Alice. Create a table, like the one below to help you tease out the details and build a reasonable inference.

Every day after work Paul took his muddy boots off on the steps of the front porch. Alice would have a fit if the boots made it so far as the welcome mat. He then took off his dusty overalls and threw them into a plastic garbage bag; Alice left a new garbage bag tied to the porch railing for him every morning. On his way in the house, he dropped the garbage bag off at the washing machine and went straight up the stairs to the shower as he was instructed. He would eat dinner with her after he was “presentable,” as Alice had often said.

What the text says	My Life Experience/Observations	Inference of what this means

3. Summarize Paul and Alice’s relationship.
4. How did you draw these conclusions about Paul and Alice’s relationship?

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4.3: Creating Tone and Mood with Thoughtful Diction

Much of how we comprehend comes from not only what is communicated, but also **how** it is communicated. This sentence, for example, can mean a number of things depending upon which word is stressed.

I never said he took my cupcake.

- I **I** never said he took my cupcake.
- I **never** said he took my cupcake.
- I never **said** he took my cupcake.
- I never said **he** took my cupcake.
- I never said he **took** my cupcake.
- I never said he took **my** cupcake.
- I never said he took my **cupcake**.

Tone and Mood

- One of the ways writers create feeling (**tone and mood**) with their writing by thoughtful use of word choice (**diction**.) Additionally, writers use sentence structure and word order to emphasize certain tones and moods.
- **Tone** describes an attitude: the attitude of the author toward the audience or topic, or in fiction, the attitude of a character regarding the readers or the storyline.
- **Mood** is specifically a feeling created by the writing.
- The important thing about tone/mood is that it serves to strengthen the connection between author and audience. Readers who are attentive to tone/mood are better able to analyze the author's perspective and are able to make more accurate inferences about the author's message. Authors use tone to give their writer's voice some personality and, in some cases, authority – which helps readers to care one way or the other about the message. The mood created in a text is designed to elicit a response from the reader. In this way, tone/mood strengthen and deepens communication between author and audience.

Diction and Word Choice

One of the subtle ways authors create their writing style is by their use of diction. **Diction** is another way of saying 'word choice.' If someone tells you that you have 'good diction,' they're saying that you have a good vocabulary and you use it well. Diction is something to pay attention to when you are reading, listening, speaking or writing.

Homework 4: Reading Process and Analysis

Read the article provided by your instructor for Homework 4. Follow and complete the steps for SQ3R, making notes in your notebook. Answer the following questions in complete sentences and paragraphs when appropriate.

1. Analyze the author's purpose.
2. Create a graphic organizer of the information.
3. Summarize the information using a strategy we have learned in this class.
4. Identify the subtleties by making an Inference Chart.
5. Explain the tone and mood, giving examples to support your ideas.
6. Explain the diction and word choice, giving examples to support your ideas.

Be prepared to discuss your analysis with the class.

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4.4: Facts, Opinion, Basic Fallacies

Another style choice authors make is the use of fact and opinion.

Always Question Facts

For our purposes, the term **fact** refers to information that can be verified or proven. While this might sound very straightforward, there is more to it. It is always a good idea to question the ‘facts’ people present to you.

Facts often include numbers in the form of data or statistics. Empirical studies, or research, might also be considered to be factual. However, all facts are not created equal.



Source

The source of the facts being presented matters.

For example, you may read an article on smoking. If the author uses a study funded by a tobacco company that says smoking is healthy for you, you may want to question the *validity* of those ‘facts.’ The tobacco company stands to benefit a great deal if everyone suddenly takes up smoking in order to improve their health. This actually happened in the 1950’s in the United States.

Take the time to find the source of facts. In today’s political scene, for example, organizations are formed for the express purpose of hiding the source of funding for political ads.

Watch political ads to see who is funding the ad. Research the organization and look to see who their donors are. This will tell you a great deal about the credibility of the facts they present.

Inclusion, Exclusion

When considering the validity of a text, you will want to consider not only the source of the information, but also something more subtle – what information did the author *include*, and what did the author *exclude*.

Have you ever heard a story told in such a way as to leave out key information in order to get a particular reaction? Excluding that key information is called **omission**.

Omission occurs when important information is not reported or is reported incompletely. We can think of omission as being news that should have been reported but is left out of the news we read, see and hear. When important news is omitted, we get a skewed or biased perspective.

Authors who ‘cherry-pick,’ or use facts selectively, should raise red flags for you as a thinker. At the very least, when you encounter this use or non-use of facts, you should look more deeply at the research on the subject.

Opinions Are like Noses – Everyone Has One

An **opinion** is a person's thoughts or feelings about a topic, and most everyone has opinions. Yet, just as not all facts are created equal, all opinions are also not created equal.

You may think that opinions are to be avoided in academic articles and academic writing. Quite the opposite is true. Opinions can be very valuable in academic work, but like use of fact, it is important to examine the opinion carefully.

Question Everything

The first question you will want to ask yourself is, “Why should I pay attention to this opinion?”

This question, like all good learning questions, will lead you to more questions, which will in turn help you to determine how much value to place on an opinion.

Here are some things you should consider when you are evaluating an opinion.

- Who is the source of the opinion?
- What do you know of their **world view**? (sometimes called “*point of view*.”)
- Experience with the topic?
- Economic position in society?
- Gender?
- Geographic origin?
- Culture or social group?
- Life experiences?
- Whose opinions do THEY value?
- It is unlikely you will be able to determine all of these factors regarding an author's world view. Nonetheless, you can learn a great deal by reading the “About the author” description on the article if it is present, or you can do a general internet search on the author.
- If the article comes from a peer reviewed journal, you can generally assume it is pretty solid research. **Peer reviewed journals** are just what they sound like – academic journals in which the articles must pass a panel of peer reviewers who are responsible for making sure the content meets current research standards in the field in which it is conducted.

Look Ahead

Check your syllabus. What assignments or parts of assignments are coming up to which you will apply your understanding of Fact and Opinion? When will this be due?

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4.5: Fact & Opinion in Reading

When you are reading or listening to information, evaluate the author's style as well as use of fact and opinion to determine how you should value this information.

Objectivity vs. Bias

Ideally, authors publish **objective** texts, leaving their emotions out of it. Keeping the writing too clinical, though, can alienate audiences, so with the exception of research article, you rarely see work published that is entirely objective. Even dry research articles can have hidden biases because humans are imperfect beings, and authors are human. There are going to be flaws in logic, or sometimes facts may be inadvertently omitted. That is to be expected. When we identify information as being reported objectively, we mean that the author did a reasonable job of reporting the information unemotionally.

On the other end of the spectrum, is something that has a negative connotation – **bias**. We use the term **bias** to refer to an author who presents information in a way that is prejudiced and does not present differing opinions fairly, or at all.

In academic reading, and in daily life, it is important to have the ability to identify and evaluate information that is presented objectively or with bias.

Exercises

In-Class Exercise 4.5: Fact vs Opinion

Your instructor will provide you with a text. Answer the following questions.

- Read and annotate the article.
- Identify the author's use of fact and opinion, using color coding and/or "F" and "O" to identify facts and opinions in the piece.
- Is this text credible? Why or why not?

UNIT 4 Review

Create a graphic organizer (samples can be found in the Course Resources section) that you find useful to rehearse and review the information covered in this Unit.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

5: Literacy and Analysis

5.1: Understanding Literacy

5.2: Developing Cross-Disciplinary Literacy

5.3: Understanding Analysis and Persuasion

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5.1: Understanding Literacy

When you first learn to *read*, you learn to decode or simply to make sense of the symbols you see. When you first learn to *write*, you learn to use those symbols to communicate on a very basic level. We call this ability to read and write **literacy**. Literacy is also diverse, especially since we all come from different backgrounds with many different experiences that shape our knowledge base.

For example, one person may be literate when it comes to reading a car's technical manual – essentially, they'll know what it's trying to say. On the flipside, another person may look at a car's technical manual and not have any background knowledge about automobile mechanics. Without that developed background knowledge, understanding the technical manual may be a challenging task.

At some point, basic level literacy simply doesn't cut it. As you continue to learn, you move beyond those basics into more complex literacy.

Homework 5: Literacy

Read and annotate the Essay for Homework 5, written by Sherman Alexie in which he discusses his experience learning to read. It serves as an example of literacy and how his knowledge base grew. Answer the following questions in complete sentences and paragraphs.

1. Compare and contrast some of the ways Alexie developed literacy with the ways you have developed literacy.
2. Summarize an episode in your life where you (or someone close to you) were impacted by literacy level and then explain the consequence from that experience.
3. Reflecting on what you wrote for questions 1 and 2, what can you conclude about the importance of literacy in everyday life?

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5.2: Developing Cross-Disciplinary Literacy

Much like the literacy example provided in section 5.1, you may encounter situations in different disciplines where you discover your literacy strengths and weaknesses. It's important to understand that **cross-disciplinary literacy**, or developing literacy in different subjects, is crucial to your success. If a professor gives you a novel in a Literature class, you may excel at it because you've had a lot of experience reading novels in your personal time. However, another professor may give you an article in a Sociology class that may provide greater challenge because you've had less experience interpreting statistics. It's important to remember that you may have to approach readings differently depending on the class – you may have to pose different questions or focus on certain details over others to understand what a reading is trying to say.

Reading and thinking critically is a process. Deep comprehension of information requires your full use of the reading process, as well as time and patience. The following tips for high level comprehension should be helpful whether you're reading in a Math, English, Sociology, or any other class.

Tips for high level comprehension

- Give yourself adequate time to use the **reading process**.
- Plan on **marking up the text** or making extensive notes.
- Accurately **summarize** the information to assure you have the message right
- Be attentive to **your responses** as you read.
- **Process the information** in a way that is useful to you (graphic organizer, notes, outline, etc.)
- **Analyze** to determine not only what the author directly/literally says, but also for what the author indirectly says.
- Determine the **value of this information** for your purposes.

Exercises

In-Class Exercise 5.2: Cross-Disciplinary Reading Strategies

Read the following text which provides an overview of cross-disciplinary literacy. Read this carefully, taking notes, and be sure to take the self-assessment quiz at the end. We will discuss this in class.

[Specialized Reading Strategies](https://courses.lumenlearning.com/su...trategies-1-3/) (<https://courses.lumenlearning.com/su...trategies-1-3/>)

Write a 2-sentence summary of the most important points for each section of the “Specialized Reading Strategies” article.

- Online Reading Comprehension
- How to Read Effectively in Math
- How to Read Effectively in the Social Sciences
- How to Read Effectively in the Sciences
- 5 Step Approach for Reading Charts and Graphs

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5.3: Understanding Analysis and Persuasion

Analyzing a reading consists of breaking it down into different parts and examining what those different parts are trying to say. When analyzing in an essay, you describe those different parts to communicate your interpretation of meaning of the reading.

Exercises

In-Class Exercise 5.3: Analyzing a Persuasive Article

Your instructor will provide an article for this activity.

Part 1:

1. Read this article, using SQ3R.
2. Using techniques similar to what we used for annotation of Fact and Opinion, highlight and annotated this article to identify the two sides of the argument being presented. Use a different color for each side of the argument to make sure you keep the ideas clear to address in your future writing about this article.

Part 2:

Now that you have experience analyzing the messages in a text, it is important to learn how to identify various types of messages. One type you will likely encounter in the future is **the persuasive message**. Persuasive messages are often conveyed in texts that seek to create social change through drawing awareness to a social problem with the goal of solving it. The strategy below will help you begin examining persuasive messages.

Follow these steps to effectively analyze an argument. Write full sentences for each item on the checklist.

1. 1. Identify Author's Thesis – A direct statement of Author's Point/Argument. (Or was this an inferred main idea?)
2. Supporting Details – How did the author support this point? Opinions, facts, statistics, persuasive language, testimony, etc.
3. Determine structure and pattern of organization.
4. Identify the author's Worldview, Purpose, and Intended Audience.
5. Identify the Author's Tone and give examples.
6. Identify any Evidence of Bias, or Objectivity.
7. Identify Facts/Opinions
8. Evaluate 2-3 facts.
9. Make reasonable inferences, and explain what those are.
10. Reflect/Connect to the ideas presented.
11. Was argument effective? If not, what would have made it more effective?
12. Form your opinion.

Unit 5 Review

Write a brief summary of the relevant information from each subsection. Then, write a sentence or two about what stood out to you in each subsection.

1. 5.1 Understanding Literacy
2. 5.2 Cross-Disciplinary Literacy
3. 5.3 Understanding Analysis and Persuasion

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Course Resources

- Summarizing Strategies
- Graphic Organizers
- Checklist for Analysis of an Argument

Summarizing Strategies

The Important Thing Summary

This summarizing strategy uses main ideas from a passage.

- The important thing about (TOPIC) is (author's point.) Main idea sentence. Main idea sentence. Main idea sentence. The important thing about (topic) is (author's point.)

Note: there may be more or fewer main idea sentences depending upon the structure of the reading. Here is an example:

- The important thing about the Writing Process is that it has four steps. Begin by prewriting to get your ideas down. Focus yourself and compose your rough draft. Next, proofread and edit your work. Last, revise. You can repeat these last two steps until you are satisfied with your work, or at least can say "it's good enough!" The important thing about the Writing Process is that it has four steps.

The Sentence Summary

A sentence summary is a method of summarizing where you sum up a text or section of text in only one sentence. This works best with a paragraph or shorter text. The sentence you write should reflect the author's point in the section you are summarizing.

Sentence Summary Frames for Common Text Structures

- Description/Definition:
 - A _____ is a kind of _____ that...
- Compare/Contrast:
 - ___x___ and ___y___ are similar in that they both..., but ___x___..., while ___y___...
- Sequence:
 - _____ begins with..., continues with... ends with
- Problem-Solution:
 - _____ wanted..., but..., so...
- Cause/Effect:
 - _____ happens because....

Variation on the Sentence Summary

For longer texts, use the sentence summary strategy to develop a summary sentence for each paragraph or section. Assemble these sentences together with appropriate transitions to form a coherent summary paragraph.

Bulleted List Summary

Bulleted lists are commonly used in slide presentations, articles, to do lists, and they are an efficient way to notate textual material for later review.

This is a bulleted list.

- Topic
- Important Point
- Important Point
- Important Point
- Etc.

Microsoft Word and Google Docs offer a number of options for bullet point styles.

You may notice bulleted lists are used extensively in this text.

The Inference Summary

An inference is an informed assumption you make based upon the combination of information you are given (text, speech, visuals) and your own experience.

Try this strategy to develop an Inference Summary of a text. Take notes using the structure shown in the table below. Then summarize this information in a paragraph. This example only uses one excerpt, but typically you should use several excerpts.

Title: *Why Do People Deny Science?* Author: *Judith Shulevitz*

The New Republic, Oct 21, 2013

Pages/Chapter/Section: *p. 16*

What the text says	What I think this means	My response
“The urge to maintain status within one’s social network is so powerful, Kahan told me, that well-educated people will use their information-gathering and computational skills to marshal a more impressive body of evidence in support of whatever identity it is (freethinking skeptic, caring mother hen) that earns them brownie points in their troop.”	The researcher Shulevitz interviewed notes that people use their intelligence to support their existing views rather than to objectively understand the topic, in this case, climate change.	This explains so much of what happens and does not happen on facebook – why it is that nobody ever successfully persuades another person on social media to change their view on a subject.

In the article, “Why Do People Deny Science,” *New Republic* science editor, Judith Shulevitz, attempts to explain why it is that people are denying what science tells us about things like climate change. She reports the work of Yale psychologist, Daniel Kahneman, who notes that people tend to disregard objectively viewing the body of scientific research, instead choosing to pay attention to that research which support their existing views in order to “fit in.”

Graphic Organizers

The Frayer Model

The Frayer Model is a type of graphic organizer used for developing definitions of entire concepts or of individual vocabulary terms. Make these on a large index card or half sheet of paper.

You can find a really great template for the Frayer Model here: <http://www.adlit.org/pdfs/strategy-library/frayer.pdf>

Outline

Topic or Chapter Title

1. 1. Introduction
 1. Focus Statement/thesis:
 1. Main Points (as outlined in the thesis statement):
 - 1.
 - 2.
 - 3.
 2. Body Paragraphs (based on main points)
 1. 1. Details and examples
 - 1.
 - 2.
 2. Conclusion

MS Word has automated numbering options to help you to set up this kind of outline.

Mapping

You can find templates and examples for mapping online. It's best to use your own system though. One word of caution with mapping – it can be messy! Plan on making more than one draft of your map.

Comparison/Contrast

The best method for graphing Comparison and Contrast is a Venn diagram. You can find a good one here: <https://www.eduplace.com/graphicorga...r/pdf/venn.pdf>

Checklist for Analysis Of An Argument

Follow these steps to effectively analyze an argument. Write full sentences for each item on the checklist.

1. ☐ Identify Author's Thesis – A direct statement of Author's Point/Argument. (Or was this an inferred main idea?)
2. ☐ Supporting Details – How did the author support this point? Opinions, facts, statistics, persuasive language, testimony, etc.
3. ☐ Determine structure and pattern of organization.
4. ☐ Identify the author's Worldview, Purpose, and Intended Audience.
5. ☐ Identify the Author's Tone and give examples.
6. ☐ Identify any Evidence of Bias, or Objectivity.
7. ☐ Identify Facts/Opinions
8. ☐ Evaluate 2-3 facts.
9. ☐ Make reasonable inferences, and explain what those are.
10. ☐ Reflect/Connect to the ideas presented.
11. ☐ Was argument effective? If not, what would have made it more effective?
12. ☐ Form your opinion.

Glossary

Sample Word 1 | Sample Definition 1

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